Psychogeography's Legacy in *From Hell* and *Watchmen*

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Abstract

Although a fluid concept, 'psychogeography' retains consistent themes from its Lettrist and Situationist beginnings to its present-day British vogue. Despite this commonality, some of psychogeography's key elements are absent from *From Hell*'s fourth chapter, which dominates discussions of it with respect to Alan Moore's comics. Psychogeography is better represented by several other elements in *From Hell* in light of its consistent semiotic and political themes. Furthermore, new ways of reading spatial relations in Moore's other work, such as *Watchmen*, appear when one considers psychogeography in a manner consistent with its history. A preliminary analysis of the role of psychogeography, as constructed in light of its French legacy in these two graphic novels, reveals deep structural similarities between them. These similarities include a celebration of the everyday citizen, comparable to the Situationist psychogeographers' own rejection of fine art as a specialised cultural category removed from the aesthetic practice of everyday urban life.

Keywords: local, London, monstrosity, Moore, psychogeography, Situationism, spatiality, *Watchmen*

Comic strips are the only truly popular literature of our century. Cretins marked by years at school have not been able to resist writing dissertations on them.[1]

From Hell (1999) is, after *Watchmen* (1987), arguably the most recognisable work in Alan Moore's œuvre, and the primary focus of discussions of psychogeography in his comics.[2] It presents a fantastic conspiracy in

1 Réne Viénet, 'The Situationists and the New Forms of Action Against Politics and Art', in *The Situationist International Anthology*, ed. and trans. Ken Knabb (Berkeley: Bureau of Public Secrets, 1995), 214.

2 Alan Moore and Eddie Campbell, *From Hell* (Paddington, Australia: Eddie Campbell Comics, 1999). Alan Moore and Dave Gibbons, *Watchmen* (New York: DC Comics,

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which Royal Physician-in-Extraordinary William Withey Gull becomes Jack the Ripper, working at the behest of Queen Victoria. Aided by Netley the coachman and prominent Freemasons, he kills several prostitutes attempting to blackmail the crown. He also turns the murders into a series of pagan ritual sacrifices. *Watchmen* tells the story of a group of superheroes uncovering an elaborate scheme by one of their compatriots, Ozymandias/Adrian Veidt, to massacre millions of New Yorkers in a bid to avert nuclear war. *From Hell*'s fourth chapter, in which Gull tours London with Netley to show him the city's historical foundation in sacrificial sexualised violence, is the cornerstone of studies of psychogeography in Moore's comics. By contrast, *Watchmen* has not been examined through this psychogeographical lens. It is this article's argument that, when situated in its historical context, Moore's psychogeography is more complex than it at first appears in *From Hell*. Gull's performance is in fact a travesty of some of psychogeography's core concepts, which have remained consistent throughout its permutations over half a century. Once one recognises Gull's limitations, other avenues appear for the exploration of psychogeography, its representation and its role in Moore's recurring themes around 'who makes the world',[3] not only in *From Hell* but also in earlier works such as *Watchmen*.

'Psychogeography', as a concept, first appears in 1954 in publications by the Lettrist International group of artists,[4] and later by the better-known Situationist International, particularly through the efforts of Ivan Chtcheglov (or Gilles Ivain) and Situationism's best-known proponent, Guy Debord. Establishing what is meant by 'psychogeography' is not simple, particularly as it has changed over time and, from the start, has been famously characterised by a 'rather amusing vagueness'.[5] Histories of Situationist psychogeography emphasise its place in histories of urban wandering more broadly, locating the idea's roots in early twentieth-century Dada and surrealist practice. At its simplest, psychogeography describes the analysis of the results of drifting, or the *dérive*, through urban space: of wandering 'to find the types of architecture

1987). All subsequent references are to these respective editions and are given in parentheses in the text in the format (chapter.page).

3 Alan Moore, '*Watchmen*' (round-table discussion with Dave Gibbons, Martin Skidmore, Fiona Jerome, Steve Whitaker and Peter Hogan), 24 June 2006, http://www.johncoulthart.com/feuilleton/2006/06/24/watchmen (accessed 3 October 2016).

4 Simon Sadler, *The Situationist City* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 1998), 169.

5 Guy Debord, 'Introduction to a Critique of Urban Geography', *The Situationists and the City*, ed. Tom McDonough (London: Verso, 2009), 59.

one desire[s] *unconsciously*'. Lettrist psychogeographers are 'travelers in a labyrinth revealed by their wish to find it', putting 'the functional design of the city to a poetic use in accordance with the wanderer's desires'.[6]

Put simply, early French psychogeography 'is articulated around a Freudian construction of the psyche . . . whereas the London incarnation registers the transformation in the relationship of individual and collective consequent on the neoliberal transformation of . . . wider spatial regimes'.[7] Perhaps one clear way in which to distinguish between French Situationist psychogeography and its English iteration is to compare their respective uses of Jack the Ripper. Guy Debord characterises Jack the Ripper as 'probably psychogeographical in love',[8] without further explanation, understandable only when considered in relation to early popular Freudian conflations of sex and violence, or love and death, which is to underscore the Situationist debt to the surrealists. Thus, the Lettrist imaginary exploration of 'the East End of London in 1888, guided by Jack the Ripper' exemplifies their investigation of the city as a 'complex of desire' that need not be literally, physically present.[9]

Iain Sinclair is arguably British psychogeography's most recognisable name, and his work has conducted a productive exchange with Moore's for many years.[10] In his novel *White Chappell Scarlet Tracings*, Sinclair employs Jack the Ripper as a means to recuperate the complex and varied local history of Whitechapel. He focuses, as so many psychogeographers do, on Whitechapel because, as 'a local community attempting to preserve its own identity', it has served historically as 'a contested site of Englishness'.[11] In practice, in Sinclair's work,

6 Christopher Gray, 'Essays from Leaving the 20th Century', in *What Is Situationism? A Reader*, ed. Stewart Home (Edinburgh: AK Press, 1996), 8; Greil Marcus, *Lipstick Traces: A Secret History of the 20th Century* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989), 173; Sadie Plant, 'The Situationist International: A Case of Spectacular Neglect', in Home, *What Is Situationism?*, 159.

7 Niall Martin, *Noise, Neoliberalism and Iain Sinclair*, Ph.D. diss., University of Amsterdam, 2012, 52.

8 Merlin Coverley, *Psychogeography* (Harpenden: Pocket Essentials, 2010), 87.

9 Marcus, *Lipstick Traces*, 385.

10 Hugo Frey and Jan Baetens, *The Graphic Novel: An Introduction* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015), 192.

11 Elizabeth Ho, 'Postimperial Landscapes "Psychogeography" and Englishness in Alan Moore's Graphic Novel *From Hell: A Melodrama in Sixteen Parts*', *Cultural Critique* 63 (Spring 2006), 118. See also Monica Germanà, 'Beyond the Gaps: Postmodernist Representations of the Metropolis', in *Land & Identity: Theory, Memory, and Practice*, ed. Christine Berberich, Neil Campbell and Robert Hudson (Amsterdam: Rodopi, 2012), 220.

psychogeographic itineraries are productive alternatives to the appropriation, exploitation or erasure of local alterity, and they are primarily imaginary interventions, useful illusions, neither true nor quite false. Sinclair's psychogeographers do not follow some magical line of force the way Gull follows a pentacle in London's streets in the fourth chapter of *From Hell*. They draw upon a force that is 'invoked. We want it and that is its truth'.[12] Similarly, Moore is clear that while the pentacle pattern is one Gull feels he has exposed, it is indeed a fictitious one that Moore has 'imposed'.[13] What French and British psychogeography share, in the construction I have placed upon them here, is an interest in motivated wandering for the purposes of providing alternative ways of understanding city space in a manner that allows for alterity, whether of the individual or the local. It has an impact upon the wanderer such that meaning cannot be said to reside in the space itself so much as in the mutually shaping *rêverie*, purposeful or not, politicised or not, of the wanderer in dialogue with it.

The psychogeographer is unlike the *flâneur*, the romantic, nostalgic, privileged, leisured, detached, masculine and possibly criminal aloof observer of urban life,[14] who so closely resembles Gull, and whose closest female correlate is, significantly in relation to *From Hell*, the prostitute.[15] While the *flâneur* remains aloof, the psychogeographer evaluates the relationship between city and self. Psychogeography studies 'the precise laws and specific effects of the geographic milieu . . . on the affective comportment of individuals', emotions that are more complex than the facile assumption that 'poor streets are depressing'.[16] The relationship is not one of interpretation but dialogue, in which both psychogeographer and city impact upon one another, often with the psychogeographer seeking to change the city,[17] either with a return to myth and dream, in the case of the Lettrists and early Situationists,

12 Iain Sinclair, *White Chappell Scarlet Tracings* (London: Granta, 1998), 137–138. The psychogeographer allows 'the *fiction* of an underlying pattern to reveal itself'. Iain Sinclair, 'Skating on Thin Eyes', in *Lights Out for the Territory* (London: Granta, 1997), 4, my italics.

13 Alan Moore and Eddie Campbell, *The* From Hell *Companion* (Marietta, GA: Top Shelf Productions and London: Knockabout, 2013), 269.

14 Coverley, *Psychogeography*, 58–60; Karen O'Rourke, *Walking and Mapping: Artists as Cartographers* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2013), 8; Martin, *Noise, Neoliberalism and Iain Sinclair*, 59.

15 Coverley, *Psychogeography*, 21; Christel Hollevoet, 'Wandering in the City: *Flânerie* to *Dérive* and After: The Cognitive Mapping of Urban Space', in *The Power of the City/ The City of Power* (New York: Whitney Museum of American Art, 1992), 47.

16 Debord, 'Introduction to a Critique of Urban Geography', 59, 61.

17 Coverley, *Psychogeography*, 72.

or a political transformation, in the case of British psychogeography. Distancing himself from early French practice but still acknowledging it, Sinclair writes that the *flâneur* is a 'spectator', while the psychogeographer is an 'actor',[18] 'drifting purposefully' in 'alert reverie' and bent on 'noticing *everything*'.[19] It is here, perhaps, that Gull departs most radically from psychogeography, in that he forces a specific reading of London upon its streets. Gull is not opposed to the rational, political forces that would render the city transparently legible: he is an extension of them.

The related Situationist practice of *détournement* – recombinations of and interventions with existing texts – began, with the Lettrists, with the innovation in 'revolutionary publications' of comics that have been *détourned*,[20] and graffiti.[21] This practice of rearranging the visual space of the page is comparable to the rearrangement of the experience of space through wandering, a homology Moore's comics exploit. Moore criticism often compares comics' suitability for the 'spatial representation of various periods . . . that "coexist" in one physical space'[22] to cityscapes, which typify a 'simultaneity of presentation . . . of temporal persistence and iterability'.[23] Typically, such analogies are followed by a comparison between the comics reader and the psychogeographer.[24]

18 Hollevoet, 'Wandering in the City', 44–45.

19 Sinclair, 'Skating on Thin Eyes', 4.

20 Robert Petersen, *Comics, Manga and Graphic Novels A History of Graphic Narratives* (Westport, CT: Praeger, 2010), 192–194.

21 Plant, 'The Situationist International', 97.

22 Seamus O'Malley, 'Speculative History, Speculative Fiction: Alan Moore and Eddie Campbell's *From Hell*', in *Graphic History: Essays on Graphic Novels and/as History*, ed. Richard Iadonisi (Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars, 2012), 171. See also Julia Round, 'London's Calling: Alternate Worlds and the City as Superhero in Contemporary British-American Comics', *International Journal of Comic Art* 10(1) (2008), 29; Germanà, 'Beyond the Gaps', 218; Christopher Murray, '"These Are Not Our Promised Resurrections": Unearthing the Uncanny in Alan Moore's *A Small Killing, From Hell* and *A Disease of Language*', in *Alan Moore and the Gothic Tradition*, ed. Matthew J.A. Green (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2013), 216; Julian Wolfreys, 'London Khoragraphic', *ImageText* 1(2) (2004), para. 6; Mark Bernard and James Bucky Carter, 'Alan Moore and the Graphic Novel: Confronting the Fourth Dimension', *ImageText* 1(2) (2004), para. 10; Sean Carney, 'The Tides of History: Alan Moore's Historiographic Vision', *ImageText* 2(2) (2006), para. 41.

23 Wolfreys, 'London Khoragraphic'.

24 O'Malley, 'Speculative History', 171; Round, 'London's Calling', 29; Murray, '"These Are Not Our Promised Resurrections"', 216; Björn Quiring, '"A Fiction That We Must Inhabit": Sense Production in Urban Spaces according to Alan Moore and Eddie Campbell's *From Hell*', in *Comics and the City: Urban Space in Print, Picture and Sequence*, ed. Jörn Ahrens and Arno Meteling (New York: Continuum, 2010), 202; Bernard and Carter, 'Alan Moore and the Graphic Novel', para. 10; Carney, 'The Tides

Such a comparison is less forced than it might seem, given that Debord himself suggested a 'psychogeographical detournement' of novels in 1956.[25] Situationist *détournement* and psychogeography as practices applicable both to space and text as a way of intervening with the 'society of the spectacle' are very similar to William S. Burroughs's use of the cut-up as a response to the 'reality film'. This latter concept speaks to a constructed reality in which anything other than passive spectatorship is nevertheless difficult to imagine.[26] Moore describes the 'reality film', in its exploration of 'the way that the word and the image are used to control, and their possible more subversive effect', as a significant influence on his work.[27]

Moore was almost certainly exposed to Situationism and psychogeography through his 'seminal' experience, as a youth, with the Northampton Arts Lab, which emphasised 'the potential boundlessness of artistic practice' and, in particular, theatre's 'collective and ritual status'.[28] In fact, the movement's founder, Jim Haynes, was among the first recipients of Alexander Trocchi's independent translations of Situationist materials into English.[29] Psychogeography, when cast as a useful illusion, resembles magic as Moore famously practises it, as a way 'to refuse the easy binary oppositions of "true" and "false"'.[30] At its core, Moore's magic concerns the manner in which art, in its power to shape one's understanding of reality, effectively shapes reality. The idea is

of History', para. 41. The same claim is made with regard to *Watchmen*, comparing the reader's position to Dr Manhattan's, in Sara J. Van Ness, *Watchmen as Literature* (Jefferson, NC: McFarland and Company, 2010), 3; Bernard and Carter, 'Alan Moore and the Graphic Novel', para. 18; Brandy Ball Blake, '*Watchmen*: The Graphic Novel as Trauma Fiction', *ImageText* 5(1) (2009), para. 7; and comparing it to Adrian Veidt's in Peter Yoonsuk Paik, *From Utopia to Apocalypse: Science Fiction and the Politics of Catastrophe* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2010), Kindle version, chap. 1; Richard Bensam, 'Obsolete Models a Specialty: An Introduction', in *Minutes to Midnight*: *Twelve Essays on* Watchmen, ed. Richard Bensam (Edwardsville, IL: Sequart Research and Literacy Organization, 2011), Kindle version.

25 Guy Debord and Gil J. Wolman, 'Methods of Detournement', in Knabb, *The Situationist International Anthology*, 11–12.

26 Timothy S. Murphy, 'Exposing the Reality Film: William S. Burroughs Among the Situationists', in *Retaking the Universe: William S. Burroughs in the Age of Globalization*, ed. Davis Schneiderman and Philip Walsh (London: Pluto Press, 2004), 42.

27 Alan Moore, interview in 'Vincent Eno and El Csawza Meet Comics Megastar ALAN MOORE', *Strange Things are Happening* 1(2) (2006), para. 12.

28 Annalisa Di Liddo, 'Transcending Comics: Crossing the Boundaries of the Medium', in *A Comics Studies Reader*, ed. Jeet Heer and Kent Worcester (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2009), 327.

29 George Robertson, 'The Situationist International: Its Penetration into British Culture', in Home, *What Is Situationism?*, 121.

30 Carney, 'The Tides of History', para. 22.

heir to Percy Bysshe Shelley's claim that poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the world, and concurs with much postmodern thought. Magicians, in Moore's work, are those who try to 'make the world', or shape its meaning, with the magic of representation, most obviously but not exclusively in Gull's gloss of London and, in *Watchmen*, Adrian Veidt's media influence. At the same time, art might be used to envision alternate possible realities that might then be brought into being.

Just as psychogeography entails a dialogue between wanderer and space, Moore insists that 'fantasy is a massive *component* of reality and cannot really be discussed as a separate entity in itself'.[31] He 'has spoken many times of writing as a magic power',[32] to explain that his interest in magic is a way – not unrelated to the Freudian *unheimlich* – to account for the manner in which signs, of which magic spells are a perfect example, shape reality. The magician takes control of, competes with or at least interferes with the machinery of the Burroughsian reality studio. Hence Moore's claim that the dictionary is a spellbook, indeed 'the most powerful *Grimoire* of magical spells' he owns. He insists, in a manner consistent with psychogeography, not only that 'all apparent entities are in fact externalized projections of parts of the self', but that the reverse is also true, which is to say that he insists on the constructed nature of the self through the reflection of one's own ideas, in a loop, through the environment.[33] In his words, 'Psychogeography [is] a means of divining the meaning of the streets in which we live and pass our lives . . . and thus our own meaning'.[34] As improvisational and nonlinear reading and writing practices, Moore's magic and psychogeography are less like simple excavations of local history – as they have been cast at times[35] – than they are comparable to Adrian Veidt's reading of television screens. Veidt himself compares his reading of the world around him with Burroughsian cut-ups, which he compares, in turn, to the 'shamanistic tradition of reading randomly scattered goat innards' (11.2), bringing us, in a sense, full circle.

31 Alan Moore, interview with Dave Sim, 'Correspondence: From Hell', in *Alan Moore: Portrait of an Extraordinary Gentleman*, ed. Smoky Man and Gary Spencer Millidge (Leigh-on-Sea, U.K.: Abiogenesis Press, 2003), 308.

32 Julia Round, 'Medium, Spirits and Embodiment in *Voice of the Fire*', in Green, *Alan Moore and the Gothic Tradition*, 249.

33 Moore, 'Correspondence: From Hell', 320, 331.

34 Alan Moore, interview, 'Alan Moore Interviewed by Eddie Campbell', in *A Disease of Language* (London: Knockabout, 2010), 116.

35 Wolfreys, 'London Khoragraphic'; Tony Venezia, '10th April, 1999, Conway Hall, Red Lion Square: *Snakes and Ladders*, Occult Cartography and Radical Nostalgia', in *Comic Book Geographies*, ed. Jason Dittmer (Mainz: Franz Steiner Verlag, 2014), 56.

From the start, *From Hell* has faced accusations of mystifying or naturalising misogynistic violence by situating it in a context of incomprehensible and/or unchangeable eternal historical recurrence.[36] However, the narrative is clear to distinguish between Gull, the actual killer, and Jack the Ripper, 'a creation of a community of readers',[37] itself an 'appropriation of earlier press strategies, sensationalist stories, and the Gothic tradition'.[38] The Ripper is a 'collage-creature' persisting in what Moore calls 'Idea Space'. He is a cultural category, and not some force of nature in a pagan 'eternal war', an idea Moore repeatedly rejects.[39] In contrast to readings that dismiss *From Hell* as simply mystifying gendered violence, careful attention to class division in *From Hell* – which is, after all, the plot's foundation[40] – and its sharp demarcation in the cityscape reveals a scarcely concealed material foundation to Gull's mysticism, and an easily overlooked mythical dimension to victim Marie Kelly's fantastic escape. The two are, as it were, embattled spirits of place.

From Hell's construction of the Ripper as a conspiracy turns the Ripper into an alibi for the systemic disenfranchisement of Whitechapel on the part of a range of London's governing, policing and religious institutions. Hence the Ripper's affiliation with the Hawksmoor churches. As David Ashford argues, Hawksmoor's churches were always intended to radiate a panoptical sensibility.[41] The Ripper and the churches are not united via some psychogeographical occult power, no matter how much Gull would like us to believe this. Like Jack the Ripper, Hawksmoor's churches are convenient spectacles of disavowal; they intimate that the causes of inequality are ineffable and natural, rather than obvious, ubiquitous and political. Christ Church Spitalfields

36 Germanà, 'Beyond the Gaps', 218; Christine Ferguson, 'Victoria-Arcana and the Misogynistic Poetics of Resistance in Iain Sinclair's *White Chappell Scarlet Tracings* and Alan Moore's *From Hell*', *Lit: Literature Interpretation Theory* 20(1–2) (2009), 58; Mervi Miettinen, '"Do You Understand How I Have Loved You?" Terrible Loves and Divine Visions in *From Hell*', in *Sexual Ideology in the Works of Alan Moore*, ed. Todd A. Comer and Joseph Michael Sommers (Jefferson, NC: McFarland and Company, 2012), 91–92.

37 Round, 'London's Calling', 623.

38 Monika Pietrzak-Franger, 'Envisioning the Ripper's Visions: Adapting Myth in Alan Moore and Eddie Campbell's *From Hell*', *Neo-Victorian Studies* 2(2) (Winter 2009–2010), 170.

39 Moore, 'Correspondence: From Hell', 321, 315, 343. See also O'Malley, 'Speculative History', 175.

40 Julia Round, 'We Share Our Mother's Health: Temporality and the Gothic in Comic Book Landscapes', in Dittmer, *Comic Book Geographies*, 128.

41 David Ashford, 'The Mechanics of the Occult: London's Psychogeographical Fiction as Key to Understanding the Roots of the Gothic', *The Literary London Journal* 10(2) (Autumn 2013), para. 20.

even barracked soldiers suppressing a tax revolt (2.15) in which Moore's own ancestors took part, only underscoring the institutional collusion.[42]

Before killing Polly, his first victim, Gull's language acts out the parody of the contradiction of middle-class stewardship of the poor as an occulted – in both senses – violence suppressing the poor. He objectifies Polly as someone for whom death would be a release given her poverty, just as he attributes Annie Chapman's illness to Whitechapel's malice and not its abject poverty (7.21). One imagines simple revision to property laws would be a path of action preferable to death (5.27), since all the victims' stories bespeak a common failure to secure financial support from a man (5.26, 7.10, 8.4). Even so, throughout the narrative, characters such as Abberline and Hinton throw up their hands like naïve readers of Gull's tour, baffled by the ultimately convenient 'evil' of Whitechapel and the 'plight of [its] unfortunates' (2.13). The murders reframe the bad faith governance that casts the material inequities, for which it is systemically responsible, as metaphysics.

Hell in *Watchmen* is a prison 'pandemonium' awash in red emergency lighting (8.18), but *From Hell* gives us multiple possible hells. Both Gull and Marie Kelly continue the narrative's interest in conflating the material and the metaphysical, such that while they give us a hell where Gull and Netley sojourn (9.31), or one to which Marie might damn the queen (1.7), or Gull, or conceivably the reader (14.23), Abberline applies the term to Whitechapel (6.22). Abberline's claim might be one way to look at the style contrast that appears as we juxtapose morning in the West End with morning in Whitechapel. There is a stark difference, but that difference is a superficial one. We certainly get a softer West End, but in the context of the narrative, it is a contrast between the West End's heaven and the Whitechapel hell it carefully manages. Gull took so much trouble to show us London's truth in the preceding chapter with his psychogeographical tour, but here we are immediately given a second London, not united in the occult, but sharply fractured by social, economic and cultural differences.

Even so, morning in Whitechapel is similar to morning in the West End when regarded solely in terms of the *relations* of capital. True, we see Gull on one side of the page in bright and spacious panels and Polly Nichols in dark and cramped ones, as chapter 5 opens. Their relationship to the world around them, however, differs only in respect to

42 Alan Moore, interview with George Khoury, 'Chapter 1: Once Upon a Time', in *The Extraordinary Works of Alan Moore*, ed. George Khoury (Raleigh, NC: TwoMorrows Publishing, 2003), 11.

the way that, as the Situationists say, 'one doesn't live somewhere in the city; one lives somewhere in the hierarchy'.[43] It is not certain that Gull's relationship to everyday events and the commodification of both Netley – whom he employs – and his wife, used to the cost of being 'a doctor's bride' (5.11), is all that different from Polly's to her customers, as she is commodified, penetrated and paid in panels facing Gull's. Their commercial relations mirror one another despite their radically different circumstances. It is possible that Netley intuits as much later, when he breaks down in tears after masturbating to a pornographic image of a female coach driver (8.18–19).

The material mirror image – similar yet reversed – is matched by a metaphysical one. The Whitechapel prostitutes parody Gull's paganism by the depiction of their morning ablutions, a bath in a cattle trough reminiscent, for Moore, of 'Diana and her nymphs bathing beside a pool' (5.7).[44] They then make their way through the city, knowledgeable of its corners and alleys, in a way that casts a more mundane, and strictly commercial, light on Gull's psychogeographical tour, implying that it is ultimately just immense privilege at play at mystifying its own power. Unlike Gull, the Whitechapel women do not have 'a permanent address between them', suggesting, perhaps, an even greater authenticity to their own wanderings (5.11). Furthermore, they remain indifferent to the historically dense landmarks around them, and wander through a space organised by market stalls and strolls and spaces at once public and private, pubs for conducting business in and pubs for leisure, improvising lodging from day to day. London is at once fractured and whole, a city and a composite of locales, unified in the occult and, paradoxically, unified in an equally dominant capitalism that may be its opposite or its equivalent. The church and the marketplace are the spatial equivalent of the tension that obtains between the art found in the Gull and Kelly homes. The Gulls have a print of Hogarth's *Reward of Cruelty*, a valued, canonical work by an artist commonly regarded as one of comics' forefathers and imbued with occult significance despite its insistence on material body horror.[45] Kelly, meanwhile, owns a frequently shown kitschy, anonymous, commercial, sentimental and popular picture of an angel (9.18, 9.48, 10.17) that has gone unmen-

43 Attila Kotányi and Raoul Vaneigem, 'Elementary Program of the Bureau of Unitary Urbanism', in Knabb, *The Situationist International Anthology*, 66.

44 Moore and Campbell, *The* From Hell *Companion*, 113.

45 See, for example, Pietrzak-Franger, 'Envisioning the Ripper's Visions', 173, and Moore and Gibbons, *The* From Hell *Companion*, 256.

tioned in Moore criticism, the metaphysical significance of which is overshadowed by its trite lack of sophistication.

After all, the London streets of *From Hell* are as dominated by advertising as they are by the churches that, for the denizens of Whitechapel at least, fail to impress. At home, Marie Kelly and her friends are paradoxically strangers to a globalised, narrativised Whitechapel made out of its iconic landmarks; their daily encounters are so utterly saturated by relations of exchange that Marie Kelly's refusal of Walter Sickert's charity is profoundly anomalous. She turns a trick instead, as she moves among market stalls where barkers cry 'hurrah for free trade' (3.2–5). Relationships that take place outside of commercial exchange in Whitechapel, such as the ones between Marie Kelly and her female lovers, or the abortive one between Emma – who may or may not be Kelly – and Abberline that fails once he commercialises it, take on additional, special significance. They become yet another way of reading urban encounters outside of the simple choices of commerce and paganism, and unlike Gull, whose perspective is fixed, Marie Kelly can slip easily among these varying perspectives on her London.

Christ Church Spitalfields looms menacingly behind the market for us; for Whitechapel's inhabitants, it is unremarkable and goes unremarked. Marie exemplifies, albeit paradoxically, as all of *Watchmen* does too, Guy Debord's sense of psychogeography as a way of interacting with urban space in a manner '*insubordinate* to usual attractions . . . catalogued under the term tourism, that popular drug as repugnant as sports or purchasing on credit'.[46] *From Hell* actually presents a 'diverging multiplicity of images and voices . . . but it seems to escape Gull' and, at times, readers.[47] Indeed, the Golden Lane street sign (9.20), in its detail, is intended to underscore the extent to which detail has inevitably been omitted from the rest of *From Hell*'s images and, through them, the possibility of foreclosing upon the ways in which London might be read.[48] Similarly, the contrasting styles in chapter 5 emphasise the simplifying artifice needed to represent London at all.

It is easier for Abberline to dismiss Whitechapel, his workplace, as belonging to 'another time' and as 'not society at all' (11.37), as 'Hell' and 'Bedlam' combined (6.22), than to understand it as the result of everyday systemic disadvantage, or as an unreadable space of cultural alterity. What forces Abberline's resignation from the police at the story's

46 Debord, 'Introduction to a Critique of Urban Geography', 62.
47 Quiring, '"A Fiction That We Must Inhabit"', 209.
48 Moore and Campbell, *The* From Hell *Companion*, 195.

end is not the discovery that the murders were intended to cover up a tawdry scandal, as it might seem, but that he is forced to admit that Whitechapel defies his claim to be an expert on it. That is, the royal scandal is not what breaks him, but the fact that he learns about it through a chance conversation with a clerk, showing him that everyone in Whitechapel seems to know about it but him (13.4). He can no longer deny that the mysterious Ripper conspiracy is only a mystery to those who prefer the convenience of bafflement to admissions of political complicity, and that his imposition of an institutionally sanctioned narrative on Whitechapel, unlike Gull's, is a simplification that fails him. The city changes for him, and changes him in turn.

The Ripper expresses collective cultural 'misogynist fantasies',[49] and seems to be the spirit of the city as a whole (9.36); he is, in a sense, all of those Londoners who write letters in his name. However, it is just as difficult to fix the identities of the victims. For example, throughout *From Hell* Marie Kelly is, by turns, Mary Kelly, Abberline's Emma, Julia, Mrs. Barnett, Mrs. Barrett, Kate Eddowes, Mary to the 'other Mary' Mary or Polly Nicholls, and ultimately the 'saint' Sickert thought of when he first laid eyes on her (1.4). If the Ripper is the monster employed in the name of political control over those disenfranchised by virtue of race, class, sexuality or gender, Marie Kelly – Irish, poor, queer and female – is the saint of their persistence as an ever-receding excess. Whether metaphysical or mundane, she is the Ripper's overlooked complement. Where Abberline likens Whitechapel to Bedlam, Gull likens Bedlam to a prison for soldiers in his eternal occult war (4.22). The material correlate of this war is class war, in which case 'the deranged women' upon whom Gull experiments (2.10) are indeed prisoners of war, a rereading of the city's institutional spaces that is further supported by Marie as 'war', the only 'whore of the apocalypse' not accounted for in her joke at the base of Christ Church Spitalfields (3.15).

Like early psychogeographers, Gull does seek to reawaken a more vital and mythic past that provides 'reasons for becoming impassioned'[50] in a feminised city.[51] Unlike them, though, he does so in order to estab-

49 Zoë Brigley-Thompson, 'Theorizing Sexual Domination in *From Hell* and *Lost Girls*', in Comer and Sommers, *Sexual Ideology in the Works of Alan Moore*, 86. See also Ali Barish, 'The Violence of Criticism: The Mutilation and Exhibition of History in *From Hell*', *Journal of Popular Culture* 38(4) (2005), 623.

50 Ivan Chtcheglov, 'Formulary for a New Urbanism', in *Situationism: A Compendium*, trans. Ken Knabb (N.p.: Bread and Circuses, 2014), Kindle version.

51 For French psychogeography, see Sadler, *The Situationist City*, 80. For *From Hell*, see Brigley-Thompson, 'Theorizing Sexual Domination in *From Hell* and *Lost Girls*', 77; Round, 'We Share Our Mother's Health', 128; Murray, '"These Are Not Our Promised

lish a totalising paradigm rather than engage in individualist aesthetic play. The psychogeographical city is to be performed, but Gull's city is 'a majestic work of art' to be 'read and interpreted'.[52] If taken seriously, Gull's tour is anything but a fracturing of the seamless institutional construction of a monolithic cityscape. It provides a different interpretive framework, but in a manner that produces no meaningful change at all in one's perspective on London beyond simply deepening the political and class inequality evident in its streets. As Gull puts it, 'Scorn not the Gods [or in this case an occult Ripper]: Despite their non-existence in material terms, they're no less potent no less terrible' (4.18). Or to put it another way, as Mexico Joe says, 'Don't never underestimate the power o' bullshit' (6.16). Magic, for Moore, is simply powerful bullshit that crafts the experience of reality: 'As any child will tell you, Magic is just pretend'.[53] There is virtually nothing in *From Hell* that can be said to be occult unless we take Gull's word for it. Given the degree to which Gull has been taken as the voice of *From Hell* despite this 'heavily touristic' psychogeographical 'parody of the Ripper Walking Tours',[54] it seems to be a powerful bullshit indeed, complementing the efforts of the *Times*, in 1888, to depict the whole of Whitechapel as a monstrous hell.[55] Readers in search of psychogeographers are better served by attending to *From Hell*'s overlooked minor characters. Abberline and Lees parody chapter 4's psychogeographical tour, Abberline playing Netley to Lees's Gull, when they travel by coach through the West End on their way to Gull's, where Gull will confess; their experience of London changes though this narrative, and they change with it. Marie Kelly is so enmeshed with the city that her reading of it, and our reading of her, is provisional and variable; indeed, in Gull's mutilation of the body that both is and is not her, we descend into a space that both is and is not the city: the extreme close-up (10.12) is 'apocalyptic in its depiction of the landscapes of the inner body', her heart 'cathedral-like', her breast 'the dome of St. Paul's'.

Resurrections"', 221; Moore, 'Correspondence: From Hell', 343; Monica Germanà, 'Madness and the City: The Collapse of Reason and Sanity in Alan Moore's *From Hell*', in Green, *Alan Moore and the Gothic Tradition*, 142.

52 Annalisa Di Liddo, *Alan Moore: Comics as Performance, Fiction as Scalpel* (Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2009), Kindle version, chap. 2.

53 Alan Moore, interview, 'Alan Moore Interviewed by Eddie Campbell', 134.

54 Elizabeth Ho, *Neo-Victorianism and the Memory of Empire* (New York: Continuum, 2012), 45–46.

55 Marie-Christine Leps, *Apprehending the Criminal: The Production of Deviance in Nineteenth-Century Discourse* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1992), 120–127.

When one approaches Moore with the clearer sense that psychogeography is more deeply invested in the mutual construction of wanderer and city, both as personal *rêverie* and as political commentary, than it is in the excavation of local history for its own sake, the possibilities for applying psychogeography as a point of entry into reading other texts such as *Watchmen* begin to emerge. Ultimately, Gull co-opts the perennially popular figure of the crazed killer, called 'Jack the Ripper' in this iteration, on behalf of state institutional control, and the Ripper is, in turn, co-opted by global capital in the theme parking of Whitechapel, as both Moore's coda to *From Hell*, 'I Keep Coming Back' (1996), and Iain Sinclair's review of the *From Hell* film assert.[56] It is at this point that Gull's appropriation of popular monster myths, in its commercialisation, meets Adrian Veidt's own monetisation of hero myths in *Watchmen* in the threat they pose to popular, alternative voices.

Rorschach/Walter Kovacs, Dr Manhattan/Jon Osterman, Silk Spectre/Laurie Juspeczyk, Ozymandias/Adrian Veidt, Bernard the newsvendor or even psychiatrist Malcolm Long are readable as variations on the psychogeographer. Furthermore, given the sheer range of ways in which it engages with spatiality, *Watchmen* potentially allows one to expand and refine the place of spatiality and psychogeography in Alan Moore in general and, perhaps, beyond his work. *Watchmen* might depict 'a postmodern reality where traditional meaning and value are denied', but that means it also 'invites readers to participate in . . . meaning-making', 'the choice of interpretation [being] up to the one who reads the blots' through their own limitations.[57] Psychogeography demands this act of meaning making, but also considers the impact of doing so on the maker of that meaning, in continuous dialogue. Or, to quote Moore, '*Watchmen*, if it offer[s] anything, offer[s] new possibilities as to how we perceive the environment surrounding us and the interactions and relationships of the people within it'.[58]

56 Alan Moore, 'I Keep Coming Back', in *It's Dark in London*, ed. Oscar Zarate (London: SelfMadeHero, 2012), 119–130; Iain Sinclair, 'Regime Change in Whitechapel', in Smoky Man and Millidge, *Alan Moore*, 279–280.

57 Ho-Rim Song, 'Text's Resistance to Being Interpreted: Unconventional Relationship between Text and Reader in *Watchmen*', in *Practicing Science Fiction: Critical Essays on Writing, Reading, and Teaching the Genre*, ed. Karen Hellekson, Craig B. Jacobson, Patrick B. Sharp and Lisa Yaszek (Jefferson, NC: McFarland and Company, 2010), 128; Van Ness, *Watchmen as Literature*, 77; Bryan D. Dietrich, 'The Human Stain: Chaos and the Rage for Order in *Watchmen*', *Extrapolation* 50(1) (2009), 131.

58 Alan Moore, in *The Mindscape of Alan Moore*, dir. DeZ Vylenz (Shadowsnake Films, 2008).

Watchmen's New York, 'largely devoid of landmarks and history',[59] is remarkably like the Situationists' Paris, not to mention Marie Kelly's Whitechapel, where landmarks are simply ignored. In particular, the newsvendor's intersection recalls the Situationist preference for 'transitory market stalls [and] small shops', 'a gap in the Parisian spectacle' of landmarks.[60] Where *From Hell* gives us Egyptian monuments such as Cleopatra's needle that are seemingly *détourned* – or repurposed – by Gull only to wind up further deepening the political fixing of spatial meaning with an occultist's veneer, *Watchmen*'s Egyptianate monuments are skyscraper quotations of obelisks and Antarctic temples built by Gull's literary precursor and historical heir, Adrian Veidt.[61] Veidt's structures are oddly prophetic protoquotations of the pyramid that tops Canary Wharf's iconic One Canada Square.[62] They are monuments whose relationship to history is not so much obscured as simply obscure, proving, in *Watchmen*, to be prophetic at best and, at worst, a killer's private joke: a varied ecology in the bleakest place on earth – Veidt's Antarctic Whitechapel, if you will – and a tomb in the heart of New York.

Watchmen's concern with space is clear from its opening page, which initiates a narrative fixation with relative scales and perspectives that remains persistent. Spatially, the opening chapter is characterised by constant repetitions of ascent and descent. The Comedian exits his apartment through the window, and Rorschach enters through it; the detectives descend by elevator, where the ground floor is 'coming up' (1.3); and Rorschach's investigation takes him to the top of Veidt's office tower, and to Nite Owl/Dan Dreiberg's underground lair. We traverse a New York already far denser than the typically horizontal experience of a car or pedestrian on the streets. The form of the opening chapter extends this alternative perspective to the reader when the chapter's opening and closing pages explode the boundedness of the city by emphasising its perhaps limitless verticality, as we open by looking down from on high to the street, but where blood flows into the sewer and to deeper, invisible depths; we then close the chapter by ascending first to a rooftop – and then beyond, to limitless heights. This conflation of, or tension between, extremes is characteristic of *Watchmen*, as, on Mars, we watch Laurie and Jon debate the value of an individual human

59 Quiring, '"A Fiction That We Must Inhabit"', 203–204.

60 Sadler, *The Situationist City*, 63.

61 Scott Brand, 'A Gordian Knot: Classical Elements in *Watchmen*', *Foundation: The International Review of Science Fiction* 43(118) (Autumn 2014), 22.

62 The construction of which began, of course, the year after *Watchmen*'s completion.

life in the context of all of creation; or Laurie and Dan, paralysed by the prospect of global annihilation, rescue citizens from a burning building, itself a retort to the Comedian's despair over fighting even supervillains when the whole world is on the brink of destruction (2.11); or we feel disgust at the Comedian's attempted rape of Sally Jupiter and the murder of his individual pregnant lover but far less, one assumes, when he admits to having done, on a greater scale, 'bad things to women. [And] shot kids' under the sanction of war (2.23).

In different ways, all of which are limited and yet impactful in the construction of possible realities, Rorschach, Dr Manhattan, Veidt and Bernard the newsvendor reprise the 'Asmodeus Flight' in which a magician flies high above the rooftops and sees, or claims to see, all from a privileged point of view.[63] All of them lay claim to being all-seeing, like *From Hell*'s Gull and Abberline, and each totalising claim is found wanting, as I will explain here. Rorschach, for example, is a kind of double psychogeographer in his double identity. As Rorschach he is analyst and judge of New York's streets, following the classic noir fashion of imagining himself the last honourable man in a fallen world. As Walter Kovacs, he appears to be a directionless mystic vagrant who wanders the streets with a sign, predicting apocalypse. Rather like Gull, he has made up his mind about New York. At the same time, Rorschach's constant use of rooftops, windows and underground passages seems to realise – or at least to allow readers to experience vicariously – the playful Lettrist utopian fantasy of a city in which citizens could roam the Paris rooftops and its Metro at night for pleasure.[64] He is, as it were, unconstrained by the rules of day-to-day uses of space. His position on rooftops suggests 'omniscience',[65] and yet his reading of New York is a foregone, foreclosed condemnation. It is oblivious to its own inconsistencies in, for example, his murder of a rapist (4.23) but dismissal of the Comedian's attempted rape of Sally Jupiter as a 'moral lapse' (1.21). In a manner of speaking, he is Gull's inverse, forcing meaning onto a 'rudderless world . . . not shaped by vague, metaphysical forces'.[66] He

63 Moore, 'Correspondence: From Hell', 326.

64 Deron Albright, 'Tales of the City: Applying Situationist Social Practice to the Analysis of the Urban Drama', *Criticism: A Quarterly for Literature and the Arts* 45(1) (Winter 2003), 93.

65 Silke Horstkotte, 'Zooming In and Out: Panels, Frames, Sequences, and the Building of Graphic Storyworlds', in *From Comic Strips to Graphic Novels: Contributions to the Theory and History of Graphic Narrative*, ed. Daniel Stein and Jan-Noël Thon (Berlin: de Gruyter, 2015), 28.

66 Mary Borsellino, '*Watchmen* and Music', in *Minutes to Midnight*.

eschews the pretence of exposing something that lies hidden, eternal and whole, and simply judges.

It is in the process of walking this world that Kovacs becomes Rorschach. After all, his mask is created from a fictitious dress made for the factual Kitty Genovese, a woman whose murder in 1964, said to have been witnessed by passive observers, became a touchstone for anxieties around a society turned into inert spectators of the Burroughsian 'reality film'. Rorschach is born when Kovacs becomes – like his contemporary, Batman of *The Dark Knight Returns* – a direct actor intervening in the life of the city through his vigilantism, in spite of a world that reinforces passivity. Whereas Kitty Genovese would be a ritual sacrifice in Gull's eyes, Rorschach regards her death as indicative of a world corrupt beyond redemption.[67]

While Jon and Laurie's debate on Mars is significantly removed from wandering in city space, it nevertheless illustrates, in abstract, the psychogeographical principle of subject interacting with space in a manner that both impacts the individual observer and opens onto possible broader critique. In both form and content, the chapter depicts a coming together of radically different scales of perspective. Jon's totalising near-omniscience is so broad a view that it overlooks such details as the need for Laurie to breathe (9.3), though it does help her to see the pattern that reveals her paternity. Laurie's is so narrow that its uniqueness brings Jon back to Earth, but out of curiosity concerning the gaps in his knowledge, not love. Laurie, in short, takes the seamless vision of creation Jon presents and destroys 'its harmonic arrangement',[68] intuiting her paternity without having to see it from an elevated position, as we do. It establishes a new, interesting pattern for Jon, and a suddenly, radically reordered landscape for Laurie. The 'smiley face' formation of the Argyre Planitia surrounds her, an entire landscape made into a midpoint between the whole of Mars and her father's badge. Like the city, the Argyre Planitia and her paternity contain her. She cannot step outside them to see them, objectively, as wholes. She can only read, interpret and intuit them, returning to Earth transformed.

Both Veidt and Dr Manhattan have often been compared to readers of *Watchmen*. The reader is in a position of superior knowledge like Dr Manhattan, and of pattern recognition like Veidt. Veidt, like Gull,

67 Horror writer Harlan Ellison also constructs Kitty Genovese's murder as a ritual sacrifice in a 1973 short story: Harlan Ellison, 'The Whimper of Whipped Dogs', in *Deathbird Stories* (New York: Collier Books, 1983), 2–19.

68 Stuart Moulthrop, 'See the Strings: *Watchmen* and the Under-Language of Media', *Electronic Book Review* (12 October 2011), para. 35.

approaches the world with an assumed reading he expects the world to uphold. The opposite of Laurie, he presupposes an impossible degree of objectivity and lays claim to truth. Hence Veidt has no qualms about simply assuming what drove the Comedian's despair, and it is, characteristically, a narcissistic assumption: 'professional jealousy' and fear of obsolescence in the face of peace (11.24–25). It is difficult to imagine a more literal appropriation of voice than to put words in the mouth of the man you killed. Veidt speaks for the whole world just as he usurps the voice of the dead Comedian, depriving it of the chance to speak its reality and 'usurping human agency'.[69] He simultaneously claims to see the city/world as he himself constructs it, through his careful marketing and advertising expertise, based on his interpretation of currents in contemporary culture. Simply put, Veidt is a perfect example of Moore's idea of the world's most proficient magicians: advertisers who use the magic of word and image 'to shape our culture'.[70] Unsurprisingly, then, he also plays out the predictions made both by Burroughs and the Situationists: that advertising would eventually appropriate their methods.[71] As the Situationists might have said of Veidt, he speaks for 'the society of alienation, whose . . . project is to prevent people from living while it organizes their survival'.[72] He sells to them on the one hand, and kills them for their own good on the other, assuming, in effect, ownership of New York City, and management of its survival.

If *From Hell* harbours a tension between larger-than-life figures who impose readings on the streets of London and average citizens who negotiate it and negotiate *with* it daily, something similar plays out in *Watchmen*. Here, those most open to transforming how they see the streets and to being transformed by them are New York's most typical, unostentatious, overlooked citizens. They too – again like *From Hell* – are not only the ones who walk its streets daily, but who die en masse while our protagonists carry on like generals who die in bed. They are anonymous figures made memorable only by virtue of their role in this narrative; otherwise they would simply be more deindividualised bodies on the streets or in the Comedian's Vietnam, a part of the landscape. They would be akin to the generic figures – a young boy, a lesbian couple, a pair of lovers kissing – who disappear in a flash of Klieg lights when the A-bomb strikes in the theatrical piece *A Day in the Life of Hiro-*

69 Carney, 'The Tides of History', para. 19.
70 Vylenz, *The Mindscape of Alan Moore*.
71 Murphy, 'Exposing the Reality Film', 50.
72 Anonymous, 'Geopolitics of Hibernation', in Knabb, *The Situationist International Anthology*, 77.

shima, cited by Moore in 1988 as an influence for *Watchmen*'s catastrophe.[73] They are bodies 'beyond your wildest imaginings' (12.6), words taken from Veidt's answer to the bodybuilding ads of a Charles Atlas. They are unimaginable not only in their number, but literally so, in their general invisibility in so many tales about threatened masses: war stories, superhero adventures, zombie apocalypses and so on. They are silent generic bystanders, deindividualised fodder going unimagined, even in the context of mass-marketed fantasies still occasionally labouring under the misnomer of "popular" culture.

Like its pedestrians, the newsvendor's intersection where this drama plays out is unremarkable too, free of looming churches and landmarks, significant only by virtue of *Watchmen*'s act of witness. Generic as it might be, Dave Gibbons insists it is an actual New York corner, or something like it. It is a 'feasible corner' drawn from 'an isometric projection of New York' and at the same time unlocatable, because New York is always in the process of becoming, the map obsolete before its ink is dry.[74] Here, shortly before they die, the everyday participants in *Watchmen* flow with, change and are changed by the city in a continual loop, coming to rest, before the blinding flash, in a rebuke of Rorschach's despair at the death of Kitty Genovese. We see them, strangers, care for one another. And when we survey the carnage, we are put in the position of superheroes/tourists, strangers with little investment in what has played out here: 'The one spot that you never see is where Jon and Laurie are standing'.[75] We are standing still in the panoramic view that opens chapter 12, a paralysis unlike the slow pan and zoom that introduced the reader to this corner, physically moving through it, at the opening of chapter 3. Then, the newsvendor seemed initially stuck, parroting the news and mistaking it for opinion,[76] and now, his dying gesture is a spontaneous act of compassion focused not on some distant potential battlefield, but the boy next to him.

The corner, like the text itself, is as dense with signification as Jon's universe, or Veidt's bank of television screens, with graffiti, silhouettes, magazines, advertisements, missing persons signs, posters, newspaper covers, litter and so on. On the one hand, Bernard's response to the news is one that is typical of postmodernity for Fredric Jameson, for whom individuals living within its complexity must look for a 'flash of historical understanding' somewhere in the 'recombination of separate

73 Alan Moore, '*Watchmen*', round-table discussion.
74 Dave Gibbons, '*Watchmen*', round-table discussion.
75 Alan Moore, '*Watchmen*', round-table discussion.
76 Ibid.

columns in the newspaper'.[77] The *New Frontiersman*'s surprisingly accurate paranoia is apt as a way of modelling this understanding, however odious. While certainly more palatable, *Nova Express* is owned, after all, by Adrian Veidt (8.12), serving as another instrument of his magic. In other words, such a 'flash of understanding' is unlikely for Bernard, so long as his focus remains narrowly on headlines and not the cityscape around him, given that the columns of type are already thoroughly compromised. He demonstrates in his dying gesture an openness at last to his immediate surroundings, their density and significance, which, at the last moment, he sees and then acts upon.

Bernard is joined by other regular people with no need for a mask and no grand ambitions, at this moment, including detective Steve Fine, tellingly acting as a citizen and not an instrument of the law. He has just been suspended, his last words to us: 'I'm still me' (11.23). Malcolm Long, for his part, is made sick, or *mal*, or perhaps well, by Rorschach, who was changed in turn by Gerald Fine and Kitty Genovese and his noir-indebted experience of urban poverty. Mal reproduces the relationship between analyst and analysand with his dinner guests, making them sick or well, in an above-view panel that reproduces the symmetry with which we watch his exchange with Rorschach, his new way of seeing the world spreading like a virus, or a cure for one (6.27). He passes through the despair with which he ended his relationship with Rorschach and becomes compassionate too, rather than merely numb. He says, at the risk of delivering a deathblow to his marriage by stopping a fight in the street, 'I have to. . . . I'm sorry. It's the world' (11.20).

The two Bernards vaporise into the picture of a white square, an echo of the blank with which the chapter opened (Fig. 1), and an answer to the black square with which Rorschach's encounter with Long closes. Far from suggesting 'the absence of meaning',[78] they suggest limitless potentiality. The white squares are snow; a blanket over brilliant colours lying in wait; a blank page, paper, a picture of blankness, an absolute transparency, an oddly specific property of DC Comics demarcated by a frame, and a flash of light, which Dr Manhattan reminds us is time made into space. The black square is a representation of emptiness, but also ink, and a picture of ink, something to which we respond, like *Watchmen*, like the city is, latent with potential signification, the picture's equivalent of a dictionary *Grimoire*, and anything

77 Fredric Jameson, *Postmodernism, or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1991), 374.

78 Song, 'Text's Resistance to Being Interpreted', 127.

but empty. Nihilism 'says the impotence of nothingness, the false brilliance of its victories; . . . Nothing ends, everything begins again', as Maurice Blanchot says of Nietzschean nihilism,[79] and as Dr Manhattan reminds Adrian Veidt, not to mention the receptive reader – the pool of unshaped black ink shaping and being shaped by the blank white space of the page.

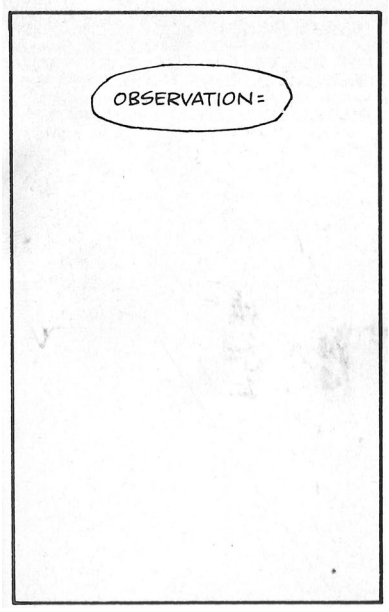


Figure 1: Chapter 11, panel 1: Ozymandias responds in a blank space. *Watchmen* © DC Comics. Written by Alan Moore and illustrated by Dave Gibbons. Courtesy of DC Comics.

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79 Maurice Blanchot, 'Reflections on Nihilism', in *The Infinite Conversation*, trans. Susan Hanson (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 149.

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